the benefits of PMAY and MNREGA despite being well-off. The state was forced to conduct an internal enquiry and publicly admit in December 2022 that 1.7 million ineligible people made it to the PMAY beneficiary list.

At the sit-in, Mamata stated that she was fighting for rural workers, and termed the non-payment of wages for completed work an "economic blockade" of the Centre. The Sangharsh Manch has reasoned that though Section 27 does have the provision of stopping funds, it cannot stop paying workers within 15 days of work done.

Just as during the 2021 assembly polls campaign, Mamata stoked regional sentiments and Bengali pride during the dharna. "They are planning to starve us to death. Bengal fought against the British...we will never be subservient to anyone." She compared her "fight" against the Centre as one against feudalism and a war against a force that treats states as colonies.

While seeking to denounce the Centre for its alleged bias against Bengal, Mamata announced her solidarity with the Opposition, and called for a united fight against the BJP in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. It was a move away from her earlier declared position—that of a non-Congress opposition front—and is consistent with the TMC's support for Rahul Gandhi and the Congress after he was disqualified from the Lok Sabha. "This union will involve one and all and I will make sure it doesn't fall to bits," Mamata said.

Political analyst Biswanath Chakrabarty sees the dharna as a choreographed attack against the BJP, besides an effort towards staying relevant in national politics. "Mamata is making it clear to the minorities that she is committed in her battle against the BJP. This is also a tactic to win back those Muslim voters who had started to shift towards the Congress and the Left, as the Sagardighi bypoll result showed." Thus, her heightened anti-BJP pitch, feels Chakrabarty, has to do with the TMC's fear of the Left and the Congress returning as a potent force in Bengal and eating into her Muslim vote share. ■



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# #GOINGTHEEXTRAMILE

We often find ourselves in a situation where we're tempted by the prospect of driving on the wrong side of the road to cut down a kilometre or two from your commute or save a few minutes by avoiding traffic on the correct side of the road. Some of us are able to resist that temptation, but some end up acting on it. Well, you shouldn't. There's never an acceptable reason for it. Excuses are plenty, but none of them are valid enough, none of them give you the right to go the wrong way. Not only does doing that disrupt the flow of traffic, but also endangers your life and of fellow road users. Ideally, even the thought of driving on the wrong side of the road shouldn't cross your mind. In case you have done that in the past then we urge you to not do so ever again. Be patient, drive that extra kilometre, spend a few more minutes in traffic, make use of a legitimate U-turn.

Same logic applies to driving on the highway as well. In case you find yourself driving past the exit you were supposed to take, miss it and carry on in the right direction instead of cutting across the lanes or stopping and trying to reverse. Yes, it adds kilometres and minutes to the journey but, that's the safe way and the right way. And, as we've pointed out already, pick the right lane and indicate properly before making your move. Using the car's in-built navigation or phone mirroring apps like Apple CarPlay and Android Auto can go a long way in helping you plan ahead and ensuring you don't miss that turn or the exit, especially if you find yourself driving through unfamiliar locales. If your car isn't equipped with these features, invest in a phone mount and use your phone's Google Maps to guide you.